ISSUE BRIEF | VANCOUVER

H1 2026 · SEMI-ANNUAL

A Lakive issue brief comparing EIU global livability rankings with occupation-based housing affordability, rent pressure, and after-tax income for local workers.

Published H1 2026 · lakive.com/reports

#9	16.2 yr	9/12	8/12
EIU Global Rank 2026	**Benchmark HPI**	**Occupations Difficult+**	**Rent Burden >40%**
Out of 173 cities	Median salary $75K	HPI Years >= 13	Of gross income

Executive Summary

The Economist Intelligence Unit ranks Vancouver #9 among 173 global cities in 2026 — the only North American city in the top 10. The ranking reflects genuine strengths: political stability, world-class healthcare, natural beauty, and cultural infrastructure that few cities can match.

But livability rankings do not measure whether a nurse can afford to stay. Lakive's analysis finds that **only 3 of 12 occupations** can realistically pursue homeownership in Vancouver on local wages. For the remaining **9 occupations — representing the majority of Vancouver's workforce** — the financial math is either difficult or not realistic at current price and income levels.

The EIU Global Liveability Index scores cities across five categories: stability (25%), healthcare (20%), culture and environment (25%), education (10%), and infrastructure (20%). Vancouver scores exceptionally well on these measures — its healthcare system is universal, its environment unmatched in North America, and its political stability is among the highest globally.

What the EIU does **not** measure: whether a nurse earning $84,000 per year can afford a two-bedroom apartment without spending nearly half her income on rent. Whether a teacher on $78,000 can realistically accumulate a down payment within a decade. These describe the financial reality of most of Vancouver's working population.

HPI Years = gross income years needed to buy a median 2BR home. RPI = annual 2BR rent as % of gross salary. Vancouver benchmark: $3,100 CAD/month · HPI base 16.2 yrs at $75K.

Occupation	Salary	HPI Yrs	Rent %	Verdict
Family Physician	$230K	5.3	16.2%	Strongly Recommended
Dentist	$185K	6.6	20.1%	Strongly Recommended
Lawyer	$130K	9.3	28.6%	Recommended
Software Engineer	$110K	11.0	33.8%	Proceed with Caution
Pharmacist	$105K	11.6	35.4%	Proceed with Caution
Civil Engineer	$90K	13.5	41.3%	Proceed with Caution
Registered Nurse	$84K	14.5	44.3%	Difficult

Occupation	Salary	HPI Yrs	Rent %	Verdict
Electrician	$82K	**14.8**	**45.4%**	Difficult
Data Analyst	$80K	**15.2**	**46.5%**	Difficult
Secondary Teacher	$78K	**15.6**	**47.7%**	Difficult
Social Worker	$65K	**18.7**	**57.2%**	Very Difficult
Retail Associate	$42K	**28.9**	**88.6%**	Not Realistic

Strongly Recommended: HPI < 7 & RPI < 30% · Recommended: HPI < 10 & RPI < 36% · Proceed with Caution: HPI < 13 or RPI < 42% · Difficult: HPI ≥ 13 & RPI ≥ 42%

At Vancouver's current price-to-income ratio, only workers earning above approximately $115,000 per year achieve an HPI Years score below 11 — the threshold where homeownership becomes a realistic medium-term goal. In practice, this means homeownership is accessible to physicians, dentists, lawyers, and senior software engineers — professions representing a small minority of Vancouver's total workforce.

> *"A nurse earning $84,000 per year in Vancouver faces a housing affordability ratio of 14.5 years — nearly twice the threshold at which Lakive rates a market Recommended. At a 20% savings rate on after-tax income, she would need over two decades to accumulate a standard down payment."*

The rent situation offers little relief. For 8 of 12 occupations analyzed, annual rent on a median 2BR apartment exceeds 40% of gross income — the threshold most financial planners consider the danger zone for long-term wealth accumulation. For social workers (57.2%) and retail workers (88.6%), renting a standard family-sized apartment in Vancouver leaves little room for savings or financial stability.

Calgary, also ranked in the EIU's global top 20 (#18, 2025), illustrates how dramatically affordability can differ within the same country and immigration system. Calgary's benchmark HPI is 8.5 years — nearly half of Vancouver's 16.2. Alberta's 0% provincial income tax adds $5,000–$15,000 in annual take-home income for most professionals compared to British Columbia.

Occupation	VAN HPI Yrs	YYC HPI Yrs	VAN Rent Burden	YYC Rent Burden
Registered Nurse	14.5	7.6	44.3%	27.1%
Software Engineer	11.0	5.8	33.8%	20.7%
Secondary Teacher	15.6	8.2	47.7%	29.2%
Lawyer	9.3	4.9	28.6%	17.5%
Electrician	14.8	7.8	45.4%	27.8%
Social Worker	18.7	9.8	57.2%	35.1%

A nurse in Calgary faces 7.6 years HPI and 27.1% rent burden — placing her in "Manageable" territory. The same nurse in Vancouver faces 14.5 years and 44.3% — firmly "Difficult." Both cities are livable. Only one makes financial sense for most workers.

Works financially for:

- High-income professionals (physicians, dentists, lawyers)
- Dual-income households above $180K combined
- Remote workers earning USD or high-CAD tech salaries
- Those who purchased property before 2016

Financially strained for:

- Single-incor
- Newcomers
- Public secto
- Anyone exp

This distinction matters most for newcomers, who face the market with no existing equity, limited Canadian credit history, and often a credential recognition gap that temporarily suppresses income. For this group, landing in Vancouver at entry-level wages while paying 50%+ of income to rent leaves virtually no room to build the capital base needed to eventually transition to ownership.

Vancouver's affordability crisis is structural, not cyclical. It is driven by supply constraints rooted in geography, political resistance to density, and sustained demand from domestic and international buyers. Interest rate movements shift monthly carrying costs — they do not address the fundamental price-to-income gap.

Meaningful improvement would require either a sustained increase in housing supply (particularly purpose-built rental and entry-level ownership), a significant rise in median wages for mid-income occupations, or both. Neither is likely to materialize rapidly. Provincial housing policy has accelerated rezoning since 2023, but new supply takes years to translate into price relief.

For workers and newcomers making location decisions in 2026, Vancouver's global livability ranking is one data point among many. It captures real quality-of-life advantages. It does not capture whether those advantages are financially accessible to the majority of people who work there.

Methodology

HPI Years = benchmarkHpi × (medianSalary / occupationSalary). Vancouver: benchmarkHpi = 16.2 at $75,000 CAD. **RPI** = (avgRent2BR × 12 / salary) × 100. Vancouver: $3,100 CAD/month. Salary data: Statistics Canada, Government of Canada Job Bank, Indeed CA (2025–2026). Housing/rental data: CMHC, Zumper, MLS (2025–2026). EIU ranking: Economist Intelligence Unit Global Liveability Index 2026 official release. Lakive is not affiliated with the EIU or The Economist Group. Cities, employers, or institutions cannot buy better scores or influence Lakive's methodology.
